

## Layer 2 — Operating Model

Jonathan Erdmann — Last Updated: May 2026

The living roadmap. Translates Layer 1 strategy into an executable, milestone-gated plan organized as a node hierarchy. Every element traces to a parent. Every initiative has a definition of done. Every phase has a gate condition, not just a timeline.

**Node hierarchy:** Breakthrough Goal → Annual Objective → Initiative → Action Item

**ID convention:** BG = Breakthrough Goal, AO = Annual Objective, IN = Initiative, AI = Action Item. Numbering restarts under each parent node.

### Phase Structure

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#### **Phase 1 — Foundation and Credential (2026–2027)**

Gate: SMU EMBA complete; LinkedIn and resume rewritten for strategy positioning; internal visibility at Collins established with at least one executive sponsor identified.

#### **Phase 2 — Positioning and Transition (2027–2028)**

Gate: Strategy-adjacent role or formal corporate strategy function secured within Collins at Senior Manager level or above.

#### **Phase 3 — Perform and Credential for Corp Dev (2028–2029)**

Gate: At least one consequential strategic work product with traceable executive decision completed; M&A adjacent exposure initiated.

#### **Phase 4 — Advance and Optionality (2029–2031)**

Gate: Positioned credibly for corporate development role; CVC optionality assessed.

### **BG-01 — Complete the SMU Executive MBA with Distinction**

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Target: May 2027. The most time-bound and definitive goal in the plan.

#### **AO-01 — Complete Term 3 Maintaining GPA on Track for Distinction (2026)**

*IN-01 — Strategic Management (STRA-6231)*

- Google 2014 Case Analysis — due May 22 (*confirm submitted*)
- Quiz: Competitive Advantage — due May 22 (*confirm submitted*)
- AI Wars Case Analysis — due May 30
- Chainsaw 1978 Case Analysis — due May 30
- Komatsu in China Case Analysis — due May 30
- Quiz: Industry Analysis — due May 30
- Blockbuster Case Analysis — due Jun 13

- Disney Pixar Case Analysis — due Jun 13
- AI21 Case — due Jun 13
- Quiz: Competing Over Time — due Jun 13
- Strategic Analysis Project first draft — due Jun 13
- Newell Case Analysis — due Jun 27
- P&G Case Analysis — due Jun 27
- Quiz: Business Diversification — due Jun 27
- Final Project — due Jul 11

*IN-02 — Managing Operations for Executives (BA-6230)*

- Group Assignment 1 — due May 30
- Group Assignment 2 — due Jun 13
- Group Assignment 3 — due Jun 27
- Read *The Goal* by Goldratt (ongoing through term)
- Group Assignment 4 — due Jul 11
- Final Exam — Jul 11

*IN-03 — Global Business Project (BA-6210)*

- Class 1 prep and quiz — May 22 (*confirm submitted*)
- Class 2 prep — May 29 (*confirm submitted*)
- Class 3 project milestone and prep — Jun 12
- Class 4 project review and prep — Jun 26
- Final Group Project presentation (virtual, 25 minutes) — Jul 10

**AO-02 — Complete Term 4 Maintaining GPA on Track for Distinction (2026)**

*IN-01 — Transformational Executive Leadership*

- Obtain syllabus and populate assignments

*IN-02 — Strategic Cost Management*

- Obtain syllabus and populate assignments

*IN-03 — Valuation and Analysis*

- Obtain syllabus and populate assignments

*IN-04 — Corporate Financial Policies*

- Obtain syllabus and populate assignments

**AO-03 — Complete Term 5 and Graduate with Distinction (2027)**

*IN-01 — Term 5 Preparation*

- Submit Term 5 elective selections to advisor

*IN-02 through IN-05 — Term 5 courses to be defined once enrolled.*

**BG-02 — Establish a Credible Professional Narrative and Targeted Network**

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Success condition: the right people inside Collins and within the broader A&D corporate strategy community know who you are, understand what you are building toward, and would surface your name when a relevant opportunity arises.

**AO-01 — Complete LinkedIn and Resume Rewrite for Corporate Strategy Positioning (2026)**

*IN-01 — LinkedIn Profile Rewrite*

- Draft revised headline and about section using positioning thesis
- Reframe experience entries to surface strategic work products
- Build out skills section with strategy-relevant keywords
- Request two targeted recommendations — one superior, one peer
- Schedule SMU Career Management Center profile review session
- Publish profile and establish baseline LinkedIn search appearance metric
- Track monthly search appearances filtered by corporate strategy and corporate development keywords; target consistent month-over-month growth

*IN-02 — Resume Rewrite*

- Schedule SMU Career Management Center resume review session
- Incorporate CMC feedback and finalize resume for corporate strategy targeting
- Tailor summary section to corporate strategy target function

**AO-02 — Establish Internal Visibility at Collins and Identify Executive Sponsor (2027)**

*IN-01 — Build Executive Visibility within RTX*

- Inform Kandyce of intent to reach out to Laura and confirm her awareness

- Reach out to Laura for a 20-minute informational interview on how she navigated the engineering-to-general-management transition at Collins
- Identify one or two additional internal Collins contacts through the Laura conversation
- Reach out to Amanda (RTX Talent) for a conversation on navigating the RTX ecosystem and making career planning efforts more robust
- Reconnect with Kathy (former RTX mentor, Director level) for a strategic conversation on the corporate strategy transition path
- Identify 2 to 3 additional senior leaders at Collins whose remit touches corporate strategy, business development, or general management
- Find credible contexts for engaging each — program reviews, cross-functional initiatives, or direct conversations
- Prepare a clear and confident answer to the question “what are you working toward?” consistent with your positioning thesis
- Participate in at least one Collins-internal initiative with visibility above your current management chain

#### *IN-02 — Secure Executive Sponsorship*

- Based on visibility-building conversations, identify one senior leader with both organizational authority and genuine interest to advocate for your transition
- Make a direct and specific ask for periodic guidance and advocacy as you develop toward a strategy-adjacent role
- Establish a regular cadence of touchpoints — quarterly at minimum — to keep the sponsor informed of your progress

### **AO-03 — Build Targeted Network in Corporate Strategy at Large A&D Primes (2026–2027)**

#### *IN-01 — External Network Development at Large A&D Primes*

- Research corporate strategy and corporate development functions at L3Harris, Northrop Grumman, Lockheed Martin, and BAE Systems
- Identify 20+ specific individuals at Director level or above in target functions
- Build a simple contact tracking list with name, company, function, and connection status
- Send personalized connection requests with clear and credible context
- Convert 5+ connections into substantive conversations via call or informational interview

- Leverage SMU Cox alumni network specifically for A&D strategy professionals
- Attend at least one A&D industry event where corporate strategy professionals are present

*IN-02 — LinkedIn Content and Professional Visibility*

- Draft and publish 3 to 5 articles at the intersection of A&D domain knowledge and strategic analysis
- Engage consistently with content from target contacts to build visibility before direct outreach
- Track engagement metrics on published content — views, comments, shares

**BG-03 — Transition into a Strategy-Adjacent Role at Collins Aerospace**

At the Senior Manager level or above. Collins is the first-move target. An external move to a large prime is the contingency if internal advancement stalls, assessed at the annual review.

**AO-01 — Expand Current Role Scope to Include Strategy-Adjacent Activities (2026)**

*IN-01 — Sustain Baseline Performance in Current Engineering Management Role*

- Maintain billable utilization at or above target for all three teams
- Document results with revenue impact framing for use in internal visibility conversations

*IN-02 — Pursue Strategy-Adjacent Activities within Current Role*

- Identify and volunteer for bids and proposals opportunities within Collins
- Contribute to at least one capture strategy or BD effort with visibility to senior leadership
- Identify other strategy-adjacent activities within current role scope — program strategy, resource planning, make/buy analysis — and actively pursue involvement
- Document contributions to strategy-adjacent work as part of internal positioning narrative

**AO-02 — Pursue Strategy-Adjacent Scope or Role within Collins (2027)**

*IN-01 — Sustain Baseline Performance in Current Engineering Management Role*

- Maintain billable utilization at or above target for all three teams
- Document results with revenue impact framing for use in internal visibility conversations

*IN-02 — Continue and Deepen Strategy-Adjacent Activities within Current Role*

- Build on BD and capture strategy involvement established in AO-01
- Expand scope of strategy-adjacent contributions — seek ownership of a discrete strategic problem or initiative
- Document contributions as evidence for internal role transition conversations

*IN-03 — Identify and Research Target Roles within Collins and RTX*

- Map corporate strategy, business development, and general management roles within Collins and RTX at Senior Manager level or above
- Identify which business units and functions are most receptive to internal transitions from engineering management
- Track posted and anticipated openings in target functions

*IN-04 — Build Relationships with Hiring Managers in Target Functions*

- Leverage executive sponsorship and internal network to identify hiring managers in target functions
- Initiate conversations with hiring managers before roles are posted
- Position yourself as a known internal candidate through consistent visibility and direct relationship development

*IN-05 — Execute Formal Application and Selection Process*

- Apply to at least one internal Collins or RTX strategy-adjacent role when a credible opportunity is identified
- Use SMU CMC resources for internal mobility coaching and interview preparation
- Prepare and rehearse a clear and compelling narrative for internal interviews grounded in positioning thesis

**BG-04 — Own a Consequential Strategic Work Product with Traceable Executive Decision**

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Success condition: a market assessment, portfolio recommendation, competitive analysis, or strategic initiative where the link between the work and the decision is direct and attributable.

**AO-01 — Deliver at Least One Consequential Strategic Work Product (2028–2029)**

*IN-01 — Identify and Own a High-Visibility Strategic Initiative*

- Within first 90 days in a strategy-adjacent role, identify the highest-impact analytical or strategic problem available to own

- Propose ownership of the initiative to your manager with a clear framing of the problem, the analytical approach, and the expected output
- Deliver a structured work product — market assessment, competitive analysis, portfolio recommendation, or strategic initiative — with a clear recommendation and supporting logic
- Present findings to senior leadership and document the decision or action that resulted

*IN-02 — Build a Personal Library of Strategic Work Products*

- Maintain a running record of strategic analyses, frameworks, and recommendations produced in role
- Ensure each work product is documented with the decision it informed and the outcome that followed
- Use this library as the evidence base for future positioning conversations and career reviews

**AO-02 — Develop M&A Adjacent Exposure (2029)**

*IN-01 — Build M&A Process Knowledge and Exposure*

- Identify internal transaction support, partnership structuring, or build/buy/partner analysis opportunities within Collins or RTX
- Volunteer to support at least one M&A adjacent process — due diligence, integration planning, or strategic partnership evaluation
- Complete at least one structured M&A or corporate development course or certification to formalize process knowledge

**BG-05 — Be Positioned Credibly for a Corporate Development Role at a Large A&D Prime**

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With M&A adjacent exposure and financial modeling depth sufficient to compete as a serious candidate. Directional objectives to be refined at Phase 3 annual review.

**AO-01 — Develop Financial Modeling Depth Sufficient for Corporate Development (2029–2030)**

*IN-01 — Build Applied Financial Modeling Capability*

- Apply Valuation and Analysis and Corporate Financial Policies coursework from EMBA in a professional context
- Identify opportunities within strategy role to build and present financial models — business cases, investment analyses, portfolio valuations
- Complete at least one external financial modeling course or certification beyond the EMBA — candidates include CFA Level 1 or a dedicated financial modeling program

- Develop fluency with M&A valuation methodologies — DCF, comparable company analysis, precedent transactions

## **AO-02 — Position Credibly for a Corporate Development Role (2030–2031)**

### *IN-01 — Build Corporate Development Market Presence and Candidacy*

- Identify and research corporate development functions and active practitioners at RTX, L3Harris, Northrop Grumman, and Lockheed Martin
- Develop relationships specifically within corporate development functions at large primes — distinct from the broader strategy network
- Assess internal RTX corporate development opportunities as a first-move option given existing relationships
- Prepare a corporate development-specific positioning narrative grounded in strategy credentials, M&A exposure, and financial modeling depth
- Target at least one corporate development role application with a complete and compelling candidacy